CMake Tutorial Verification on Windows Server 2025

Analysis of CI-Driven Build System Testing

`2026-03-10` (CI Run Timestamp)

Abstract

This document analyzes a GitHub Actions workflow that systematically validates the CMake build system by executing the official CMake Tutorial suite on a **Windows Server 2025** infrastructure. The workflow uses recursive `make` invocations to test specific CMake capabilities including **Generators**, **Add Executable**, **Add Library**, and **Target Link Libraries**. The analysis includes the actual source files and build configuration to demonstrate the verification process.

1 Introduction

This CI pipeline treats the CMake Tutorial not as documentation, but as a set of unit tests for the build system itself. By recursively calling `make` on isolated tutorial modules, the workflow transforms documentation into a comprehensive verification suite that confirms:

- CMake can generate Unix Makefiles on Windows
- The MinGW64 toolchain (GCC 15.2.0) functions correctly
- Static library generation and linking work properly
- Error handling (non-zero exit codes) is managed correctly

2 Environment and Tooling

The execution environment is characterized by a very recent software stack:

- **Operating System:** `Microsoft Windows Server 2025` (Build 10.0.26100)
- **Runner Image:** `windows-2025` (Version `20260302.43.1`)
- **CMake Version:** `3.31.6`
- **Compiler:** GNU GCC `15.2.0` (MinGW64)
- **Make:** GNU Make `4.4.1`
- **Git:** `2.53.0.windows.1`

```
2026-03-09T17:32:29.5260023Z Current runner version: '2.332.0'
2026-03-09T17:32:29.5284100Z ##[group]Runner Image Provisioner
2026-03-09T17:32:29.5284948Z Hosted Compute Agent
```

3 File System Hierarchy

The tutorial is organized in a hierarchical structure based on the directories referenced in the build logs:

```
tutorial/
  generators/
    UNIX/
      add_excutable/
        src/
          main.cc
      add_library/
        include/
          42.h
          answer.h
        lib/
          answer.cc
      target_link_libraries/
        include/
          42.h
          answer.h
        lib/
          answer.cc
        src/
          main.cc
```

4 Workflow Architecture: Recursive Make

The core mechanism of this CI pipeline is the recursive invocation of `make`. The top-level script runs `make -C tutorial`, which in turn invokes `make -C [submodule]`. This architecture allows the CI to isolate and verify specific CMake features without polluting the global build state.

4.1 The Execution Tree

The log reveals a four-level nesting structure:

1. **Level 1:** `make` (Top-level entry)
2. **Level 2:** `make -C tutorial`
3. **Level 3:** `make -C generators`
4. **Level 4:** `make -C [UNIX, add_excutable, add_library, target_link_libraries]`

5 Tutorial Modules - Source Code

5.1 Add Executable Module

This module demonstrates a simple executable returning an exit code.

Listing 1: src/main.cc

```
int main () { return 42; }
```

5.2 Add Library Module

This module demonstrates static library creation.

Listing 2: include/42.h

```
#ifndef ANSWER
#define ANSWER 42
#endif
```

Listing 3: include/answer.h

```
#ifndef ANSWER_H
int answer();
#endif
```

Listing 4: lib/answer.cc

```
#include "answer.h"
#include "42.h"
int answer () { return ANSWER; }
```

5.3 Target Link Libraries Module

This module demonstrates linking an executable against a static library.

Listing 5: src/main.cc (modified)

```
#include "answer.h"
int main () { return answer(); }
```

6 Build System Configuration

6.1 CMakeLists.txt Structure

Based on the logs provided for the `add_executable`, `add_library`, and `target_link_libraries` modules, the build system utilizes modern CMake syntax (specifically `target_sources`). The configuration corresponds to the following logic:

Listing 6: Modern CMakeLists.txt Structure

```
cmake_minimum_required(VERSION 3.31)
project(tutorial)

Add Executable
add_executable(main)

Add Library
add_library(answer)

Target Link Libraries
target_link_libraries(main answer)
```

Listing 7: Source Assignment via target_sources

```

Assigning sources to targets (as seen in logs)
target_sources(main
```

```
PRIVATE
src/main.cc
)

target_sources(answer
PRIVATE
lib/answer.cc
PUBLIC
FILE_SET HEADERS
BASE_DIRS
include
FILES
include/answer.h
)
```

6.2 Generated Makefile

The generated Makefile confirms proper CMake configuration and path handling on the Windows Server environment.

Listing 8: Generated Makefile Structure

```
default_target: all
.PHONY : default_target

CMAKE_COMMAND = "C:/Program Files/CMake/bin/cmake.exe"
CMAKE_SOURCE_DIR = D:/a/rabbit-holes/rabbit-holes/cmake-tutorial/generators/UNIX
CMAKE_BINARY_DIR = D:/a/rabbit-holes/rabbit-holes/cmake-tutorial/generators/UNIX/
    build
SHELL = /bin/sh
```

7 Build System Analysis

7.1 Unix Makefiles on Windows

A critical aspect of this workflow is the explicit selection of the **Unix Makefiles** generator on a **Windows** OS:

```
cmake -G "Unix Makefiles" -B build
...
SHELL = /bin/sh
```

This verifies that the MinGW environment correctly supports Unix-style scripts and path handling (forward slashes) within a native Windows context.

```
find build | cat -n
      1 build
      2 build/CMakeCache.txt
      3 build/CMakeFiles
      4 build/CMakeFiles/3.31.6
      5 build/CMakeFiles/3.31.6/CMakeCCompiler.cmake
      6 build/CMakeFiles/3.31.6/CMakeCXXCompiler.cmake
      7 build/CMakeFiles/3.31.6/CMakeDetermineCompilerABI_C.bin
      8 build/CMakeFiles/3.31.6/CMakeDetermineCompilerABI_CXX.bin
      9 build/CMakeFiles/3.31.6/CMakeRCCompiler.cmake
     10 build/CMakeFiles/3.31.6/CMakeSystem.cmake
```

8 Observations

8.1 Exit Code 42

The workflow explicitly handles non-zero exit codes. In the `add_excutable` module, the program `main` is configured to return `42`:

```
# The will return
# make: [all] Error 42 (ignored)
./build/main
```

This demonstrates that the CI pipeline is robust enough to treat this specific exit code as a successful validation of error-handling logic rather than a build failure.

8.2 CMake Configuration Log

The CMake configuration output shows successful compiler detection:

```
-- The C compiler identification is GNU 15.2.0
-- The CXX compiler identification is GNU 15.2.0
-- Detecting C compiler ABI info
-- Detecting CXX compiler ABI info - done
-- Check for working C compiler: C:/mingw64/bin/cc.exe - skipped
-- Check for working CXX compiler: C:/mingw64/bin/c++.exe - skipped
-- Configuring done (8.7s)
-- Generating done (0.0s)
-- Build files have been written to: ...
```

9 Conclusion

The workflow validates that CMake can function correctly on Windows Server 2025 with the following key takeaways:

1. **Portability:** Unix Makefiles function correctly on Windows Server 2025 with MinGW.
2. **Modernity:** The environment supports the latest versions of GCC (15.x) and CMake (3.31.x).
3. **Resilience:** The pipeline successfully manages non-zero exit codes associated with tutorial logic.
4. **Verification Suite:** The CMake Tutorial is transformed from documentation into a comprehensive verification suite.

The actual source code demonstrates the hierarchical structure of CMake projects and confirms that the build system correctly handles:

- Executable compilation
- Static library generation
- Linking executables against libraries
- Cross-platform makefile generation